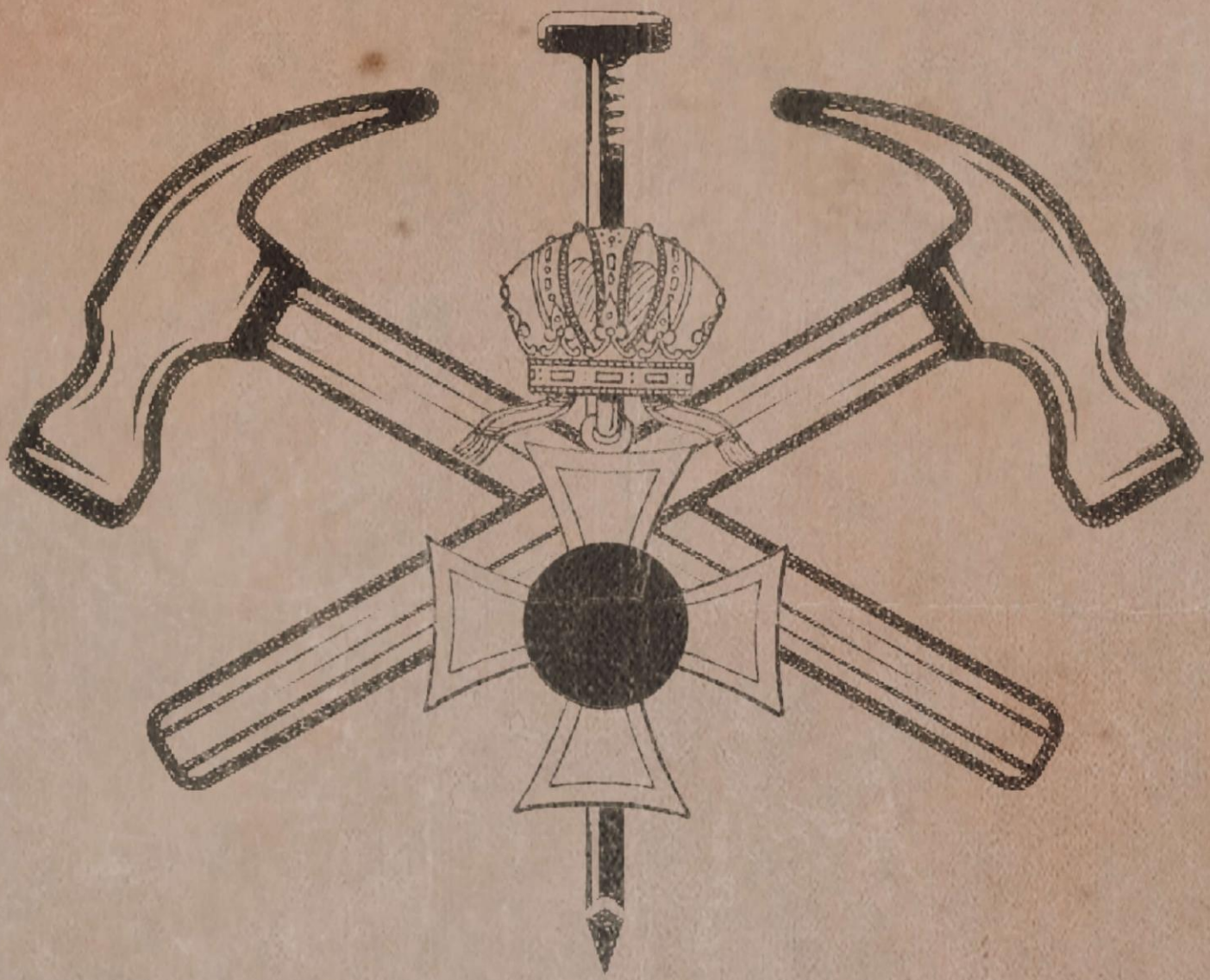
HAMMER & NAIL



SPECIAL EDITION

Dear Readers, a document has been brought to our attention by reliable sources; a document which was to have been printed in one of those publications favored by so-called revolutionaries, and which has, thanks to our timely intervention, now been prevented from appearing in that form.

We present it to you here in full, without mitigation; a text which has the audacity to claim that our Emperor and his government, under the influence of agents from neighboring states, might themselves constitute a danger; yes, that certain parties wished to provoke a war by means of a conspiracy, foiled only by one self-styled detective by the name of Janus Oxxenford.

This text illustrates the methods to which these traitors to the people resort in their efforts to besmirch the Empire; to drag us down to their own level.

We therefore counsel our readers, on the basis of our own thorough investigation, that nothing contained in these defamatory scribblings has ever occurred, or can be shown to have occurred.

You have been warned.

The account which follows is not my own. It was set down by another hand; a hand not devoid of imagination, and not entirely devoid of accuracy, though the two qualities are not always found together in its pages. I have read it, as one reads official documents, with a certain weary interest; and I have added, in the margins, such corrections as seemed to me necessary. The reader will find them in the usual place.

The account begins, as such accounts generally do, with the authorities.

During the winter of 1886-87 imperial **[imperial; the account deploys this word with a comfort I have never managed; empires are, in my experience, chiefly remarkable for the quantity of munitions they store and the quantity of simple folk they rouse from their slumbers]** government officials made a strange and secret investigation of certain conditions in the commune of Nussdorf, at the edge of the Donau. By April the matter had become public; a vast series of raids and arrests occurred, and the supposedly empty houses along the abandoned waterfront were closed and placed under guard. It was, the officials said, a sanitary measure. Only one paper; a tabloid always discounted because of its wild policy; asked why a sanitary measure required a dark vessel to discharge fire downward in the murky waters just beyond the Donauinsel.

The night of the vessel was, by all accounts, a still one. Above, the stars were shining brightly, and below, the lights of the shipping glimmered in the dark water. It was on such nights; when the ice was right and the lane along the waterfront deserted; that Von Herling was said to land on the Donauinsel. He was, in my considered opinion, inspecting the arrangements. The arrangements were not completed. **[Von Herling; naturally; the account does not dwell on this; I have long had an eye upon him, and the ice, and the night, and what was intended for those crumbling houses along the waterfront]**

A remarkable man this Benjamin Blasic **[remarkable; I watched him for two years and picked him as he ripened, which is not, in my experience, what one does with remarkable men]**; a man who could hardly be matched among all the devoted agents **[devoted; dangerous, perhaps, or useful, but not devoted; the account is, in this passage, being a little generous with its adjectives]** of the Kaiser. It was his talents which had first recommended him for the Viennese mission, the most important mission of all, but since he had taken it over those talents had become more and more

manifest to the half-dozen people in the world who were really in touch with the truth. His present companion on this particular evening was Baron Von Herling, the chief secretary of the legation, whose huge carriage was blocking the country lane outside Blasic's house as it waited to waft its owner back to the city. Further down that same lane, a small Fiaker stood in the dark. Its coachman: a thickset, grey-moustached man of few words who had served me on enough such occasions to have developed, among other things, a reliable instinct for wine and a reliable instinct for silence; sat waiting with the patience of long practice. Beside him in the box seat, Lambert, trusted companion and the most blithe boy of my acquaintance, had settled himself with the air of one who has been permitted, under close supervision, to hold the reins for a short stretch of the road from Klosterneuburg; an arrangement which had cost the coachman, I need not add, some considerable anxiety. Blasic and the secretary stood with their heads close together, talking in low, confidential tones.

"So far as I can judge the trend of events, you will probably be back in Berlin within the week," the secretary was saying. "When you get there, my dear Blasic, I think you will be surprised at the welcome you will receive. I happen to know what is thought in the highest quarters **[the highest quarters; I have long had an eye upon them and found them, without exception, a little heavy-handed; the somnolence is, I assure you, quite genuine]** of your work in this country."

Blasic laughed. "They are not very hard to deceive," he remarked. "A more docile, simple folk could not be imagined."

"I don't know about that," said the other thoughtfully. "It is that surface simplicity of theirs which makes a trap for the stranger. One's first impression is that they are entirely soft. Then one comes suddenly upon something very hard, and you know that you have reached the limit and must adapt yourself to the fact. They have, for example, their insular conventions which simply must be observed."

"Meaning 'good form' and that sort of thing?" Blasic sighed as one who had suffered much**. [suffered much; he was two years living it down; I have spent my pensive nights in considerably worse company than a cabinet minister's country house, and I do not call that suffering]** "Meaning Austrian prejudice in all its queer manifestations. As an example I may quote one of my own worst blunders; I can afford to talk of my blunders, for you know my work well enough to be aware of my successes. It was on my first arrival. I was invited to a weekend gathering at the country house of a cabinet minister. The conversation was amazingly indiscreet."

Blasic nodded. "I've been there," he said dryly. "Exactly. Well, I naturally sent a résumé of the information to Berlin. Unfortunately our good chancellor **[our good chancellor; good; a word the account deploys here with a solemnity I find, in my present mood, a little rich; heavy-handed is the word I would use, and the account has already used it, which is as close to the truth as official documents generally get]** is a little heavy-handed in these matters, and he transmitted a remark which showed that he was aware of what had been said. This, of course, took the trail straight up to me. You've no idea the harm that it did me. There was nothing soft about our Austrian hosts on that occasion, I can assure you. I was two years living it down. Now you, with this sporting pose of yours "

"No, no, don't call it a pose. A pose is an artificial thing. This is quite natural. I am a born sportsman. I enjoy it."

"Well, that makes it more effective. You skate against them, you hunt with them, you play fencing, you match them in every game, your four-in-hand takes the prize at the Prater. I have even heard that you go the length of boxing with the young officers. What is the result? Nobody takes you seriously. And all the time this quiet house of yours is the centre of half the mischief in Vienna, and the sporting squire the most astute secret-service man in Europe. Genius, my dear Blasic; genius!" **[genius; the account is laying it on rather thick; I have furnished that genius with thoroughly untrustworthy material for two years; a man who stores his most vital papers behind a combination lock set to Winter 1882 is not, I need not add, a genius]**

"You flatter me, Baron. But certainly, I may claim my four years in this country have not been unproductive. I've never shown you my little store. Would you mind stepping in for a moment?"

The door of the study gave straight on to the terrace. The patterns of the objects within all hinted of remote secrets and unimaginable abysses in time and space, and the monotonously aquatic nature of the reliefs became almost sinister; it took no excessive sensitiveness to beauty to make one literally gasp at the strange, unearthly splendor of the alien, opulent phantasy that rested there on a purple velvet cushion. **[purple velvet cushion; the account lingers here; I had eyes for nothing but the safe]** Blasic then closed the door behind the bulky form which followed him and carefully adjusted the heavy curtain over the latticed window.

"But you have a good dossier there already."

"Out of date and wastepaper. The Admiralty in some way got the alarm and every code has been changed. It was a blow, Baron; the worst setback in my whole campaign." **[the worst setback; the alarm was not accidental; I have, in my laborious days, found that alarms of this kind rarely are]**

Von Herling looked at his watch and gave a guttural exclamation of disappointment. "Well, I really can't wait no longer. You can imagine that things are moving at present in the Ballhausplatz **[the Ballhausplatz; things are always moving at present in the Ballhausplatz; they move chiefly in the direction of high explosives and gunboat attack, and I find the whole arrangement, on reflection, a little nauseous]** and that we have all to be at our posts. I had hoped to be able to bring news of your great coup. Did Altamont name no hour?"

Blasic pushed over a telegram. The message read simply: ***ALTAMONT***.

"Escapement wheels, eh?"

"You see he poses as a clockwork expert and I keep a full workshop. In our code everything likely to come up is named after some spare part. If he talks of a mainspring it is a battleship, of a gear wheel, a cruiser, and so on. Escapement wheels are naval signals."

"From the Arsenal at midday," said the secretary, examining the superscription. "By the way, what do you give him?"

"Five hundred Schilling for this particular job. Of course he has a salary as well."

"The greedy rogue. They are useful, these traitors, but I grudge them their blood money." **[blood money; the account records this with a disapproval I find, coming from a man whose carriage is blocking the country lane while the arrangements for making high explosives are, as he himself has noted, well under way, quietly remarkable]**

"I grudge Altamont nothing. He is a wonderful worker. If I pay him well, at least he delivers the goods, to use his own phrase. Besides he is not a traitor. I assure you that our most pan-Germanic Junker is a sucking dove in his feelings towards Austria as compared with a real bitter Hungarian-American."

"Oh, a Hungarian-American?"

"If you heard him talk you would not doubt it. Sometimes I assure you I can hardly understand him. He seems to have declared war on the language as well as on the Emperor himself. **[the Emperor himself; the old gentleman; the account grants him weight throughout, as naturally as if it were deserved; a man who is on his hind legs and fair ramping is not, in my experience, a fixed point in a changing age]** Must you really go? He may be here any moment."

"I'm sorry, but I have already overstayed my time. We shall expect you early tomorrow, and when you get that signal book through the little door on the Stephansplatz steps you can put a triumphant Finis to your record in Vienna." **[triumphant Finis; the account cannot resist a theatrical flourish; I would call it simply: the end]** He indicated a heavily sealed dust-covered bottle which stood with two high glasses upon a salver. "May I offer you a glass before your journey?"

"No, thanks. But it looks like revelry."

"Altamont has a nice taste in wines, and he took a fancy to my Tokay. He is a touchy fellow and needs humouring in small things. I have to study him, I assure you." **[a touchy fellow; I am not touchy; I am careful; there is a difference which this account has not, in its laborious pages, managed to grasp]** They had strolled out on to the terrace again, and along it to the further end where at a touch from Von Herling's coachman the great carriage shivered and chuckled. "Those are the lights of Klosterneuburg, I suppose," said the secretary, pulling on his winter coat. "How still and peaceful it all seems. There may be other lights within the week, and the Austrian roads a less tranquil place! The heavens, too, may not be quite so peaceful if all that the good Zeppelin **[the good Zeppelin; good; the account is fond of this word in connection with heavily armed things]** promises us comes true. By the way, who is that?"

She was bending over her knitting and stopping occasionally to stroke a large black cat upon a stool beside her. "That is Martha, the only servant I have left."

The secretary chuckled. "She might almost personify old Vienna," he said, "with her complete self-absorption and general air of comfortable somnolence. Well, au revoir, Blasic!" The secretary lay back in the cushions of the luxurious carriage, with his thoughts so full of the impending European tragedy **[the impending European tragedy; I have, in my pensive nights, found that European tragedies are prepared in the Ballhausplatz with fifty million Schilling and a storage of munitions; the tragedy is not impending; it is already in the safe, neatly packed, and thoroughly untrustworthy]** that he hardly observed that as his carriage swung round the village street it nearly passed over a small Fiaker coming in the opposite direction. I had slipped back into the study by then, and from the latticed window I watched the last gleams of the carriage lamps recede along the frozen lane; and beyond them, at the edge of the dark, the vast expanse of the Donau lay cold and still under the night sky, as remote and sinister as the commune of Nussdorf itself.

Across the room stood a leather valise beside Blasic's table; I caught him packing the contents of his safe, very neatly and systematically, as was his habit. **[paste, most of it; I had furnished a good many of these papers myself]** As I recalled the foreboding commune of Nussdorf; once glimpsed from the narrow road as I rattled along its cobblestoned streets; the vast huddle of sagging gambrel roofs and peaked gables drifted back to me, conveying with offensive clearness the idea of wormy decay. The ruins of wharves jutted out from the frozen shore, hollow and damp; the most nauseous fishy odor imaginable pervaded everything. It lingered a moment and then faded. I had seen enough. I slipped out through the terrace door before Blasic could turn round, took up my position in the lane, and became, for the last time, Mr. Altamont of Budapest.

Blasic was just in time to see the lights of a small Fiaker come to a halt at the gate. A passenger sprang out of it and advanced swiftly towards him, while Lambert, perched beside the coachman with the grey moustache, had at last quieted his suggestions as to the most efficient route and resigned himself to watching the gate. "The signals?" asked Blasic eagerly, running forward to meet his visitor; the same visitor who, not five minutes since, had been watching him from the latticed window. For answer the man waved a small brown-paper parcel triumphantly above his head. **[triumphantly; it was a brown-paper parcel; the account sees triumph where I saw, at best, a serviceable piece of work carried out under some difficulty]**

"You can give me the glad hand tonight, mister," he cried. "I'm bringing home the bacon at last."

"The signals?"

"Same as I said in my cable. Every last one of them, semaphore, lamp code, telegraph; a copy, mind you, not the original. That was too dangerous. But it's the real goods, and you can lay to that." He slapped Blasic upon the shoulder with a rough familiarity from which the other winced. "Come in," he said. "I'm all alone in the house. I was only waiting for this. Of course, a copy is better than the original. If an original were missing, they would change the whole thing. You think it's all safe about the copy?"

The Hungarian-American had entered the study and stretched his long limbs from the armchair. He was a tall, gaunt figure, with clear-cut features and a small goatee beard which gave him a general resemblance to the caricatures of the old Magyar noble. **[the old Magyar noble; I have been called worse; I do not object to the beard, which was grown under some difficulty in Debrecen]** A half-smoked, sodden cigar hung from the corner of his mouth, and as he sat down he struck a match and relit it. "Making ready for a move?" he remarked as he looked round him. "Say, mister," he added, as his eyes fell upon the safe from which the curtain was now removed, "you don't tell me you keep your papers in that?"

"Why not?"

"Gosh, in a wide-open contraption like that! And they reckon you to be some spy. Why, a Viennese crook would be into that with a can-opener. If I'd known that any letter of mine was goin' to lie loose in a thing like that, I'd have been a mug to write to you at all."

"It would puzzle any crook to force that safe," Blasic answered. "You won't cut that metal with any tool."

"But the lock?"

"No, it's a double combination lock. You know what that is?"

"Search me," said the Hungarian-American. "Well, you need a word as well as a set of figures before you can get the lock to work." He rose and showed a double-radiating disc round the keyhole. "This outer one is for the letters, the inner one for the figures."

"Well, well, that's fine."

"So it's not quite as simple as you thought. It was four years ago that I had it made, and what do you think I chose for the word and figures?"

"It's beyond me."

"Well, I chose Winter for the word, and 1882 for the figures, and here we are." **[Winter, 1882; it was not beyond me; I had guessed both two years before this night; a man who chooses the season and the year as his combination is not, I need not add, in a class by himself]**

"My, but that was smart! You had it down to a fine thing."

"Yes, a few of us even then could have guessed the date. Here it is, and I'm shutting down tomorrow morning."

"Well, I guess you'll have to fix me up also. I'm not staying in this goldarned country all on my lonesome. In a week or less, from what I see, the old Emperor will be on his hind legs and fair ramping. I'd rather watch him from over the water."

"But you're an American citizen?"

"Well, so was Jack James an American citizen, but he's doing time in Graz all the same. It cuts no ice with an Austrian copper to tell him you're an American citizen. 'It's Austrian law and order over here,' says he. By the way, mister, talking of Jack James, it seems to me you don't do much to cover your men."

"What do you mean?" Blasic asked sharply. "Well, you are their employer, ain't you? It's up to you to see that they don't fall. But they do fall, and when did you ever pick them up? There's James ..."

"It was James's own fault. You know that yourself. He was too self-willed for the job."

"James was a bonehead; I give you that. Then there was Hollis."

"The man was mad."

"Well, he went a bit woozy towards the end. What about Steiner?"

"Well, they've got him, that's all. You'll go off and he, poor devil, will have to stand the racket, and lucky if he gets off with his life. That's why I want to get over the water as soon as you do."

Blasic was a strong, self-contained man **[strong and self-contained; he was straining against his bonds within the hour; the account uses this description twice and I find it, on both occasions, somewhat misplaced]** but it was easy to see that the news had shaken him. "How could they have got on to Steiner?" he muttered. "That's the worst blow yet."

"Well, you nearly had a worse one, for I believe they are not far off me."

"You don't mean that!"

"Sure thing. My landlady down Favoriten way had some inquiries, and when I heard of it I guessed it was time for me to hustle. But what I want to know, mister, is how the coppers know these things? Steiner is the fifth man you've lost since I signed on with you, and I know the name of the sixth if I don't get a move on. How do you explain it, and ain't you ashamed to see your men go down like this?" **[the fifth man; I watched them, Lambert,**

and I picked them as they ripened; the account records Blasic's bewilderment without dwelling on its cause]

Blasic flushed crimson. "How dare you speak in such a way!"

"If I didn't dare things, mister, I wouldn't be in your service. But I'll tell you straight what is in my mind. I've heard that with you German politicians when an agent has done his work you are not sorry to see him put away."

Blasic sprang to his feet. "Do you dare to suggest that I have given away my own agents!" **[his own agents; five of his best were in prison; I had put them there; the account records his outrage without noting that it was, on the whole, misplaced]**

"I don't stand for that, mister, but there's a stool pigeon or a cross somewhere, and it's up to you to find out where it is. Anyhow I am taking no more chances. It's me for little Switzerland, and the sooner the better."

Blasic had mastered his anger. "We have been allies too long to quarrel now at the very hour of victory," **[the very hour of victory; I would call it the very hour of exposure; the account does not, and I have learned not to expect too much from it in this regard]** he said. "You've done splendid work and taken risks, and I can't forget it. By all means go to Switzerland, and you can get a train from Zürich to Hamburg. No other line will be safe a week from now. I'll take that book and pack it with the rest."

The Hungarian-American held the small parcel in his hand but made no motion to give it up. "What about the dough?" he asked.

"The what?"

"The boodle. The reward. The 500 Schilling. The gunner turned damned nasty at the last, and I had to square him with an extra hundred Schilling or it would have been nitsky for you and me. 'Nothin' doin'!' he says, and he meant it, too, but the last hundred did it. It's cost me two hundred Schilling from first to last, so it isn't likely I'd give it up without gettin' my wad."

Blasic smiled with some bitterness. "You don't seem to have a very high opinion of my honour," he said. "You want the money before you give up the book." **[honour; a mediæval conception, as his own companion observed not two hours before; the account passes over this in silence, and I will follow its example]**

"Well, mister, it is a business proposition."

"All right. Have your way." He sat down at the table and scribbled a check, which he tore from the book, but he refrained from handing it to his companion. "After all, since we are to be on such terms, Mr. Altamont," said he, "I don't see why I should trust you any more than you trust me. Do you understand?" he added, looking back over his shoulder at the Hungarian-American. "There's the check upon the table. I claim the right to examine that parcel before you pick the money up."

The Hungarian-American passed it over without a word. Blasic undid a winding of string and two wrappers of paper; across the cover was printed in golden letters *Practical Handbook of Bee Culture*. Only for one instant did the spy **[the spy; the account was rather more generous in its choice of words here; I have removed the master, naturally]** glare at this strangely irrelevant inscription.

"A glass for everyone…" said Janus Oxxenford as he extended the bottle of Imperial Tokay; "…except for you, Lamby; you have still to get us home, and I would prefer to arrive there without incident." Lambert, who had come in from the cold and settled himself by the table with the quiet watchfulness of one who has learned to wait without complaint, received this remark with the dignity appropriate to one who had nearly persuaded a coachman into a ditch not three hours since. The coachman had followed Lambert indoors with the air of one who does not expect to be refused and was not. "Thank you, sir," said he, with a gravity that suggested the Tokay was receiving the attention it deserved. He did not volunteer further remarks, which was, in my experience, a mark in his favour.

"A remarkable wine. Our friend upon the sofa has assured me that it is from Franz Josef's special cellar at the Schoenbrunn Palace. **[Franz Josef's special cellar; the old gentleman's cellar does not improve the wine or its owner; I have found both, on reflection, to be a little heavy-handed]** Might I trouble you to open the window, for chloroform vapour does not help the palate."

The safe was ajar, and Janus standing in front of it was removing dossier after dossier, swiftly examining each, and then packing it neatly in Blasic's valise. The German lay upon the sofa sleeping stertorously with a strap round his upper arms and another round his legs. "We need not hurry ourselves, Lambert. We are safe from interruption. Would you mind touching the bell? There is no one in the house except old Martha, who has played her part to admiration. I got her the situation here when first I took the matter up. Ah, Martha, you will be glad to hear that all is well."

The pleasant old lady had appeared in the doorway. She curtseyed with a smile to Janus, but glanced with some apprehension at the figure upon the sofa. "It is all right, Martha. He has not been hurt at all."

"I am glad of that, sir. According to his lights he has been a kind master. **[a kind master; his lights were not particularly bright; but Martha's words are Martha's words, and I will not quarrel with Martha]** He wanted me to go with his wife to Berlin yesterday, but that would hardly have suited your plans, would it, sir?"

"No, indeed, Martha. So long as you were here, I was easy in my mind."

"It was the secretary, sir."

"I know. His carriage passed by."

"I thought he would never go. I knew that it would not suit your plans, sir, to find him here."

"No, indeed. Well, it only meant that I waited half an hour or so until I saw your lamp go out and knew that the coast was clear. You can report to me tomorrow in Vienna, Martha, at the Hotel Sacher."

"Very good, sir."

"I suppose you have everything ready to leave."

"Yes, sir. He posted seven letters today. I have the addresses as usual."

"Very good, Martha. I will look into them tomorrow." As the old lady vanished, I recalled once more how the frozen Donau had wakened something in me as I drew near the commune; glimpsed from the narrow road, the lower floors of its crumbling houses harboring small shops with dingy signs, a parked cart or two as I rattled along the cobblestoned streets, the whole place and its guarded, close-mouthed people; the streets hollow and damp and receding now into the dark behind us.

"These papers," Janus continued, "are not of very great importance, for, of course, the information which they represent has been sent off long ago to the German government. These are the originals which could not safely be got out of the country."

"Then they are of no use."

"I should not go so far as to say that, Lambert. They will at least show our people what is known and what is not. I may say that a good many of these papers have come through me, and I need not add are thoroughly untrustworthy. It would brighten my declining years **[declining years; the account is here at its most imaginative; I am forty-three; the goatee adds perhaps five]** to see a German cruiser navigating the Donau according to the mine-field plans which I have furnished. There is also Nussdorf; you passed through it on the road from Klosterneuburg, you will recall, though perhaps not slowly enough to have formed an opinion of what it was intended to become. **[Nussdorf; the account is, in this passage, more discreet than accurate; the dark vessel and its fire were to provide the occasion for a suitable outrage; Austria provoked, Austria retaliates, and the war would find its convenient spark already lit; it was, I will admit, not without a certain elegance]** The plans are here, Lambert, and they are as thoroughly untrustworthy as the rest. How have the years used you? You look the same blithe boy as ever."

"I feel twenty years younger, Janus. I seldom felt so happy as when I got your wire asking me to meet you at Klosterneuburg with the carriage. But you, Janus; you have changed very little; save for that horrible goatee."

"These are the sacrifices one makes, Lambert," said Janus, pulling at his little tuft. **[one makes; the account had one makes for one's country; I have removed two words and do not miss them]** "Tomorrow it will be but a dreadful memory. With my hair cut and a few other superficial changes I shall no doubt reappear at the Hotel Sacher tomorrow as I was before this Hungarian job came my way."

"But you have retired, Janus. We heard of you as living the life of a hermit among your bees and your books in a small farm upon the Wienerwald."

"Exactly, Lambert. Here is the fruit of my leisured ease, the magnum opus of my latter years!" **[the magnum opus of my latter years; the account has, in this passage, entirely lost its grip on the calendar; I have already observed that I am forty-three; written in the margins of Blasic's own dossiers, between Bratislava and Debrecen; the account calls it leisured ease; I would call it something else entirely]** He picked up the volume from the table and read out the whole title, *Practical Handbook of Bee Culture, with Some Observations upon the Segregation of the Queen*. "Alone I did it. Behold the fruit of pensive nights and laborious days when I watched the little working gangs as once I watched the criminal world of Vienna."

"But how did you get to work again?"

"Ah, I have often marvelled at it myself. The Foreign Minister alone I could have withstood, but when the Premier also deigned **[deigned; the account uses this word without irony; I would use it with a great deal, and then put it down and use it again]** to visit my humble roof; ! The fact is, Lambert, that this gentleman upon the sofa was a bit too good for our people. He was in a class by himself. **[in a class by himself; the class being that of men who set their combination locks to the season and the year and consider themselves geniuses]** Things were going wrong, and no one could understand why they were going wrong. Agents were suspected or even caught, but there was evidence of some strong and secret central force. Those involved had a quality one encounters occasionally in men who have operated too long in the dark; a stillness, a watchfulness, a tendency to say less than they knew. It was absolutely necessary to expose it. Strong pressure was brought upon me to look into the matter. **[strong pressure; the Premier deigned to visit; I had already looked into the matter; the pressure was, on the whole, ornamental]** It has cost me two years, Lambert, but they have not been devoid of excitement. When I say that I started my pilgrimage at Budapest, graduated in a Hungarian secret society at Bratislava, gave serious trouble to the constabulary at Debrecen, and so eventually caught the eye of a subordinate agent

of Blasic, who recommended me as a likely man, you will realise that the matter was complex. Since then I have been honoured by his confidence**, [honoured by his confidence; burdened, rather; a man's confidence, when it extends to the storage of munitions and the preparation for gunboat attack, is not something one is honoured by]** which has not prevented most of his plans going subtly wrong and five of his best agents being in prison. I watched them, Lambert, and I picked them as they ripened. Well, sir, I hope that you are none the worse!"

The last remark was addressed to Blasic himself, who after much gasping and blinking had lain quietly listening to Janus's statement. He was a guarded, watchful man who said little and observed much; the kind of man, I had found, who is most dangerous when he appears most docile. The people of Nussdorf were of a different order entirely; a closed, self-contained commune that kept its own counsel and knew nothing of what had been planned in its name. Janus continued his swift investigation of documents while his prisoner cursed and swore.

"Though unmusical, German is the most expressive of all languages," Janus observed when Blasic had stopped from pure exhaustion. "This should put another bird in the cage. I had no idea that the paymaster was such a rascal, though I have long had an eye upon him. Mister Blasic, you have a great deal to answer for."

"I shall get level with you, Altamont," he said, speaking with slow deliberation. "If it takes me all my life I shall get level with you!"

"The old sweet song," said Janus. "How often have I heard it in days gone by. It was a favorite ditty of the late lamented Professor Hackenbauer; a man of considerable gifts, I will say that for him. Oberst Maximilian Strohberger has also been known to warble it, in somewhat flatter tones. And yet I live and keep bees upon the Wienerwald." **[and yet I live; I do not entirely disown the satisfaction with which the account records this; it is, I think, the most accurate sentence in the whole document]**

"Curse you, you double traitor!" cried the German, straining against his bonds and glaring murder from his furious eyes.

"No, no, it is not so bad as that," said Janus, smiling. "As my speech surely shows you, Mr. Altamont of Budapest had no existence in fact. I used him and he is gone."

"Then who are you?"

"It is really immaterial who I am, but since the matter seems to interest you, Mr. Blasic, I may say that this is not my first acquaintance with the members of your family. I have done a good deal of business in Germany in the past and my name is probably familiar to you."

"I would wish to know it," said the man on the sofa, grimly.

"It was I who brought about the downfall of the late King of Bohemia when your cousin Heinrich was the Imperial Envoy. It was I also who saved from murder, by the Nihilist Klopman, Count Von und Zu Grafenstein, who was your mother's elder brother. **[Count Von und Zu Grafenstein; I have saved a good many people in my laborious days and I do not, as a rule, find that the length of their title bears any relation to their gratitude]** It was I."

Blasic sat up in amazement. "There is only one man," he cried.

"Exactly," said Janus.

Blasic groaned and sank back on the sofa. "And most of that information came through you," he cried. "What is it worth? What have I done?" Janus found, at this point, that his attention had drifted; as it sometimes does when a man says exactly what one has expected him to say; towards the dark skyline beyond the window: collapsing huddles of gambrel roofs forming a jagged and fantastic outline above which rose the ghoulish, decapitated steeple of an ancient church, and the Donaukanal lying as deserted as the Ringstrasse below.

"It is certainly a little untrustworthy," said Janus. "It will require some checking and you have little time to check it. Your admiral may find the new guns rather larger than he expects, and the cruisers perhaps a trifle faster." **[your admiral; I have found admirals to be, without exception, a little heavy-handed; I do not expect this one to distinguish himself]**

Blasic clutched at his own throat in despair. "But you have one quality which is very rare in a German, Mr. Blasic," Janus continued, not unkindly, as he laid his hand upon the shoulder of the prostrate man. "You are a sportsman and you will bear me no ill-will when you realise that you, who have outwitted so many other people, have at last been outwitted yourself. After all, you have done your best for your country, and I have done my best, and what could be more natural? It is better than to fall before some ignoble foe. **[some ignoble foe; the account implies I am not ignoble; I will not quarrel with this; it is, I think, the second most accurate sentence in the document]** These papers are now ready, Lambert. If you will help me with our prisoner, I think that we may get started for Vienna at once."

It was no easy task to move Blasic, for he was a strong and a desperate man. **[strong and desperate; heavy, rather, and the garden walk was icy; the account has been, throughout, a little generous with him]** Finally, holding either arm, the two friends walked him very slowly down the garden walk which he had trod with such proud confidence when he received the congratulations of the secretary only a few hours before. After a short, final struggle he was hoisted, still bound hand and foot, into the inner seat of the little Fiaker, Lambert having been restored, not without some protest, to his place beside the coachman. Blasic's precious valise was wedged in beside him. **[precious; paste; but neatly packed]** "I trust that you are as comfortable as circumstances permit," said Janus when the final arrangements were made. "Should I be guilty of a liberty if I lit a cigar and placed it between your lips?"

But all amenities were wasted upon the angry German. "I suppose you realise, Mr. Janus Oxxenford," said he, "that if your government bears you out in this treatment it becomes an act of war."

"What about your government and all this treatment?" said Janus, tapping the valise. "You are a private individual. You have no warrant for my arrest. The whole proceeding is absolutely illegal and outrageous."

"Absolutely," said Janus. "Kidnapping a German subject."

"And stealing his private papers."

"Well, you realise your position, you and your accomplice here. If I were to shout for help as we pass through the village."

"My dear sir, if you did anything so foolish you would probably enlarge the two limited titles of our village inns by giving us ***'The Dangling Prussian'*** as a signpost. The Austrian is a patient creature, but at present his temper is a little inflamed, and it would be as well not to try him too far. Blasic, you will go with us in a quiet, sensible fashion to the Polizeidirektion, whence you can send for your friend the secretary, and see if even now you may not fill that place which he has reserved for you in the ambassadorial suite. As to you, Lambert; the most sharp-eyed and quick-footed of my small irregulars, and the only one among them who could be trusted to wait in a cold lane for three hours without contriving some difficulty; Vienna won't be out of your way. Stand with me here upon the terrace, for it may be the last quiet talk that we shall ever have."

The two friends chatted in intimate converse for a few minutes, recalling once again the days of the past, while their prisoner vainly wriggled to undo the bonds that held him. As they turned to the Fiaker Janus pointed back to the moonlit Donau and shook a thoughtful head. "There's an east wind coming, Lamby."

"I think not, Janus. It is very cold."

"Good Lambert! You are the one fixed point in a changing age. **[the one fixed point; and also the one who, on the road from Klosterneuburg, nearly persuaded the coachman to drive the Fiaker into a ditch with his suggestions; the account is silent on this and I think it wise]** There's an east wind coming all the same, such a wind as never blew on these lands yet." He paused; his thoughts, as they sometimes do in the small hours, drifted towards the dark water and the commune beyond it; not a living thing to be seen on the distant breakwater, not a sound save the lapping of the frozen harbor and the roar of the falls in the Donaukanal. A cleaner, better, stronger land would lie in the winter sun when the storm had cleared, and the moonlit Donau behind them would be part of that same distant world, no longer secret, no longer sinister. **[no longer sinister; the account ends on this note; I have found the Donaukanal to be sinister in all seasons, and I would not go so far as to say that a cleaner wind changes this; but it is a cleaner wind, and I will not quarrel with that, wearily]** He returned, presently, to the lane and the Fiaker and the cold. "But it's a cleaner wind none the less." He turned to the coachman. "Move along, if you please; it is time that we were on our way. I have a check for five hundred Schilling which should be cashed early, for the

drawer is quite capable of stopping it if he can." **[the drawer is quite capable; he was in prison within the week; the account ends here, and I will follow its example]**

the LANTERN

Nr. 6

A NOTE ON A RECENT FORGERY

Contributed by a Reader. Published in The Lantern, Nr. 6.

The document recently circulated under the title Janus Oxxenford: Eine Aufzeichnung, and reprinted with apparent approval by a publication which shall remain unnamed, purports to be a genuine account of events in and around the commune of Nussdorf during the winter of 1886-87, annotated in the margins by one Janus Oxxenford, described therein as a private investigator of some reputation.

A reader with any familiarity with recent popular fiction will find the text immediately suspicious. One with access to a lending library will find it conclusive.

The document is, in the main, a clumsy plagiarism. It has been assembled from no fewer than two identifiable sources, stitched together with alterations of setting and character-name, and furnished with marginal annotations in a voice so conveniently self-deprecating as to invite the question: self-deprecating on whose behalf, and to what end?

We present the evidence below. The reader may judge for themselves.

I. The Opening Passage

The document opens as follows:

> During the winter of 1886-87 government officials made a strange and secret investigation of certain conditions in the commune of Nussdorf, at the edge of the Donau… Only one paper asked why a sanitary measure required a dark vessel to discharge fire downward in the murky waters just beyond the Donauinsel. The night of the vessel was, by all accounts, a still one.

> Above, the stars were shining brightly, and below, the lights of the shipping glimmered in the dark water.

Compare this with the opening of Gudrun Nemitz, Wien: Eine Beobachtung (published Vienna, 1882), Chapter IV, in which the author describes the waterfront commune of Schwarzbach; a thinly disguised portrait of any number of Danubian villages she considered hotbeds of revolutionary agitation:

> During those months the imperial authorities made a thorough investigation of certain unwholesome conditions in the commune of Schwarzbach, at the margin of the river. By spring the matter had become a public one; arrests and searches were carried out, and the supposedly unoccupied houses along the derelict waterfront were closed by order of the garrison. Only the most excitable of the radical press thought fit to remark upon the dark vessel that had been observed in the waters below the island… The night in question was, by all accounts, a still one. Above, the stars were bright, and the lights of the river traffic moved slowly in the dark water below.

The correspondence is not accidental. The commune has been renamed, the season shifted, the phrasing varied just enough to escape immediate recognition; yet the structure, the sequence, and in several places the precise rhythm of the sentences are identical. This is not similarity. It is transcription with alterations.

II. The Dialogue

The central section of the document presents a conversation between two agents of a foreign power, identified as Blasic and Von Herling. This exchange will be familiar to readers of Walter Rapf's popular novel His Last Bow (serialised in Das Wiener Abendblatt, 1884-85), in which two foreign conspirators; named Kredl and Baron Wessing; conduct a near-identical exchange in a house outside Prague:

The document reads: "They are not very hard to deceive. A more docile, simple folk could not be imagined." / "It is that surface simplicity of theirs which makes a trap for the stranger. One's first impression is that they are entirely soft. Then one comes suddenly upon something very hard."

Rapf's original reads: "They are simpler than one expects." / "That is the danger of them. The softness is on the surface only. Beneath it one encounters, quite suddenly, a resistance one had not anticipated."

The scene continues in the document with a discussion of a sporting cover maintained by the spy; fencing, boxing with officers, prize-winning at the Prater; lifted almost verbatim from Rapf's Chapter Nine, where Kredl maintains his cover through "skating, riding, and the occasional bout of fencing with the garrison."

III. The Annotations

The marginal annotations attributed to Oxxenford deserve particular attention. They are written in a voice of studied detachment; wry, self-aware, mildly contemptuous of patriotism; and serve a very specific function: they dismiss, in advance, any suggestion that the false flag operation described in the document might be taken seriously. The annotation to the Nussdorf passage reads, in part: "not without a certain elegance." The operation is thus presented as a curiosity, admired at arm's length by its own alleged exposer.

This is not the voice of a man writing in the margins of a document he intends to expose. It is the voice of a man writing annotations designed to be read instead of the document; to replace its contents with a tone, to substitute irony for evidence.

We do not know who wrote these annotations. We note only that they were not in the document as it was first circulated, and that they appear to have been added by the same hand that prepared it for its most recent publication.

The question of why this forgery was constructed, and in whose interest, we leave to the reader. We observe only that the commune of Nussdorf exists, that the events of April last year were reported; briefly, and then not at all; in precisely one newspaper, and that the document now before you was presented to the public with a prefatory note assuring them that nothing in it had ever occurred.

A note from the author

This text is itself a form of plagiarism – a plagiarism by transposition

I have assembled Public Domain texts by

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle – His Last Bow

&

H. P. Lovecraft – The Shadow over Innsmouth

changed a few names of characters, setting and the intent of both stories to create a bastard child of a text. I think if not used for malicious intent or to deceive and scam people, plagiarism can be, to some extent, an art in and of itself.